



AN INDIAN IN FRANCE

Col. Kabilan Sai Ashok became the **youngest Indian referee** to officiate at the Olympics during Paris 2024.

Since 1904, only four Indian referees have officiated at the Olympics.

Incidentally, Col. Ashok officiated one of the most anticipated and high-voltage bouts, involving Algeria's Imane Khelif and Hungary's Luca Anna Hamori. This match followed Italian Angela Carini's withdrawal from her fight with Imane, which triggered a gender row.

Col. Ashok, the only Indian to hold the coveted position of President of the World Military Boxing Council (CISM), has also conducted bouts at the World Championships.

He is also the only Indian referee to have been fast-tracked from two-star to three-star status. Before this, Kishen Narsi and Jay Kowli officiated at the London 2012 Olympics.

Feels like home

It is a beautiful experience to witness the Parisians' love for their

country's national teams, cutting across various sports disciplines. Apart from individual events, team competitions such as football, rugby, and basketball attract large numbers of spectators to the stadiums.

In a country that's mad about football, the craze for basketball is equally amazing. When France took on the USA in both the men's and women's finals during the last two days of the Games, big crowds gathered at restaurants, cafes, and bars across the city to support their teams.

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